

Mentorship Matters

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ABSTRACT

Opening the industry to historically underrepresented artists is vital to the growth and development of the world of VFX. In an effort to support this, a pilot program was conducted at Santa Monica College to integrate a mentorship experience into a community college composition course. Existing research tells us that students are more successful when they are mentored by an industry professional. However, this mentorship often looks like an internship. Due to location, time, and money, this is unattainable for many student populations. In its place, stakeholders from across the VFX community partnered with the school to integrate mentorship into scheduled course times. While not a perfect solution given time constraints and time zone limitations, this did open the door for students to access priceless guidance from established industry professionals.

From our initial meeting to the program exit surveys, we will share our journey to embed industry experiences into an advanced composition course. Additionally, we will address the bumps along the way and where we see room for improvement.

Is an integrated mentorship element the next step in secondary and postsecondary programs? What are the implications of the program for best practices in VFX education? How do we hope to see this program grow from the pilot? What methods of evaluation could be used to determine the impact of the program?

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1 INTRODUCTION

The impact of mentorship in career development is undeniable. However, students preparing for industry roles have not always had access to a mentor. In the Spring 2022 semester, a pilot program was launched at Santa Monica College: integrating mentorship into a community college composition course. Through a mentoring program started by AccessVFX sponsored by Foundry, a team worked together to provide meaningful mentorship for historically underrepresented students at Santa Monica College.

The team began meeting months before the start of the semester. Devin Uzan, the course instructor, and Ann Marie Leahy, the college student engagement coordinator, created the course curriculum and syllabus. With the support of Kathleen Ruffalo, Emma Moonraker, Jen Goldfinch, and Kirstyn Salehi, students in the Advanced Composition course were paired with industry professionals for a series of integrated mentorship activities within the coursework including artist panels, Bring Your Own Comp events for critical feedback, networking events, and one-on-one mentoring through Prospela.

Santa Monica College is a diverse community college with students who are historically underserved and underrepresented in higher education. While many larger institutes require internships, this would be a barrier to many students at SMC. While they are strategically located for in-person mentorships, time away from work and families without pay isn't as feasible as it is for more wealthy student populations. By creating a course-embedded mentorship program with events during dedicated class time (and one-on-one mentorship happening asynchronously), our team found a way to create meaningful experiences that work with the students in time and space that works for them.

The team for this project consisted of the following members: Devin Uzan - course instructor SMC; Ann Marie Leahy - Student Success Coordinator SMC; Jen Goldfinch - Senior Director of Industry Marketing - Foundry; Kirstyn Salehi - Education Industry Manager - Foundry; Kathleen Ruffalo - Recruitment Manager - Framestore US - Access VFX; Emma Kolasinska - Executive Producer - Moonraker VFX - Access VFX. Each member of the team brings a different aspect of expertise to this project. The SMC members of the team brought their course and composition expertise alongside the expertise of the student body. Foundry members managed software needs, recruited mentors, and connected SMC to Access VFX. AccessVFX members pioneered the Prospela platform and recruited mentors.

Internships are a large part of successful larger programs. As mentioned previously, the students in smaller communities as lower-cost schools do not always have the resources to do an unpaid internship or even set time aside outside of the course to pursue a mentorship. Community colleges do not always have the connections to the industry to get their students paired with a mentor.

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To measure the success of the program, students will be asked to give feedback on their experience through exit surveys. Future research of the pilot program could include career tracking students in this course and students who took the course prior to the embedded mentorship element (or students in courses at colleges with similar demographics). If the program makes a significant difference in student success as defined by meeting their career goals, there will be evidence that mentorship should be embedded

into VFX coursework. Existing pedagogical theories suggest that mentorships and internships are helpful for student growth and career development, but the context of this program and the virtual setting will determine if this model aligns with known best practices. Since the Prospela platform is set up to be used by students of all ages, this could have strong implications for use with secondary students.